(DM) issued to the GDR by West Germany. Frederick Taylor writes that the GDR "basically set up a completely alternative, secret economy that it didn't have to account for" to deal with a shrinking economy and increased defense costs. This included sales of weapons, antiques, and black market goods and a "blatantly criminal source of foreign currency [that] came from the GDR's sale of its political prisoners to the West. Political prisoners as 'export items.'"[2] The East Germans received upward of 100,000 DM per political refugee, and the exiled refugees in turn helped support their economy. The border area along the Wall remained a pernicious and even lethal locale but with increased opportunities for cross-border interaction and management. Due to both internecine and external pressures for reform across the Soviet bloc, the geopolitical focus of the Cold War once again shifted toward sites dispersed around the globe.

Meanwhile, also at the dawn of the New Year, poet Audre Lorde faced several pressing uncertainties that coincided with the weeks surrounding her fiftieth birthday. She had just returned from her parents' Caribbean homeland of Grenada, shortly after the Reagan administration directed U.S. troops to invade the island following the ouster and execution of Prime Minister Maurice Bishop. Lorde went there to survey the aftermath of the occupation and drafted her troubled response in the essay "Grenada Revisited: An Interim Report." Her observations were a late addition to her first book of collected prose essays, *Sister Outsider*. In the first weeks of the year, she wrote the Grenada essay while she reviewed the manuscript's final edits on typeset pages. An accomplished writer and National Book Award–nominated poet, Lorde had recently authored a reflective opus, the autobiographical "biomythography" *Zami*. But her rationale for publishing her first collection of essays was in part to increase availability to wider audiences and to ensure that more of her work would survive beyond her lifetime. Two weeks before her February 18 birthday, Lorde also began weighing options, as her doctor had discovered a tumor in her liver following an acute gallbladder attack and recommended a biopsy.[3] Already a breast cancer survivor, Lorde elected to put off immediate treatment. She was wary of invasive medical approaches to treating liver cancer and thus avoided getting a firm diagnosis. Amidst these profound exigencies, Lorde kept working and followed through on a commitment she had made the year prior: to serve as a guest professor for the summer semester at the John F. Kennedy Institute for North American Studies at the Free University in West